powerful views on a certain issue, he had the capacity to drag people with him subconsciously. A senior player, particularly one of his stature and aura, has a profound responsibility to the group.

He was never nasty, but had been in hundreds of team meetings during a glittering career. If he didn't want to be there, he made it pretty obvious. Over time, that became draining. Even his staunchest supporters would concede that, to paraphrase the mischievous chat-show host Graham Norton, he was an individual in a team sport.

Helping to decide his future was the hardest aspect of my career as England captain. I had huge respect for him as a cricketer, and was determined to judge him from personal experience rather than the myths and legends that had been built around him. I had never, for instance, heard him issue the supposed 'him or me' ultimatum during his dispute with Peter Moores, so I refused to allow it to influence me.

I factored in Kevin's achievements over 104 Tests and 136 one-day internationals. Although this was strictly relative, given our collectively poor form with the bat on that Ashes tour, he had been our highest run scorer with 293. Yet I felt strongly, as captain, that we had reached the stage where we would get more out of up-and-coming players who were desperate to prove themselves.

I recommended that he should step away from the England team. All that remained was for the firestorm to break.